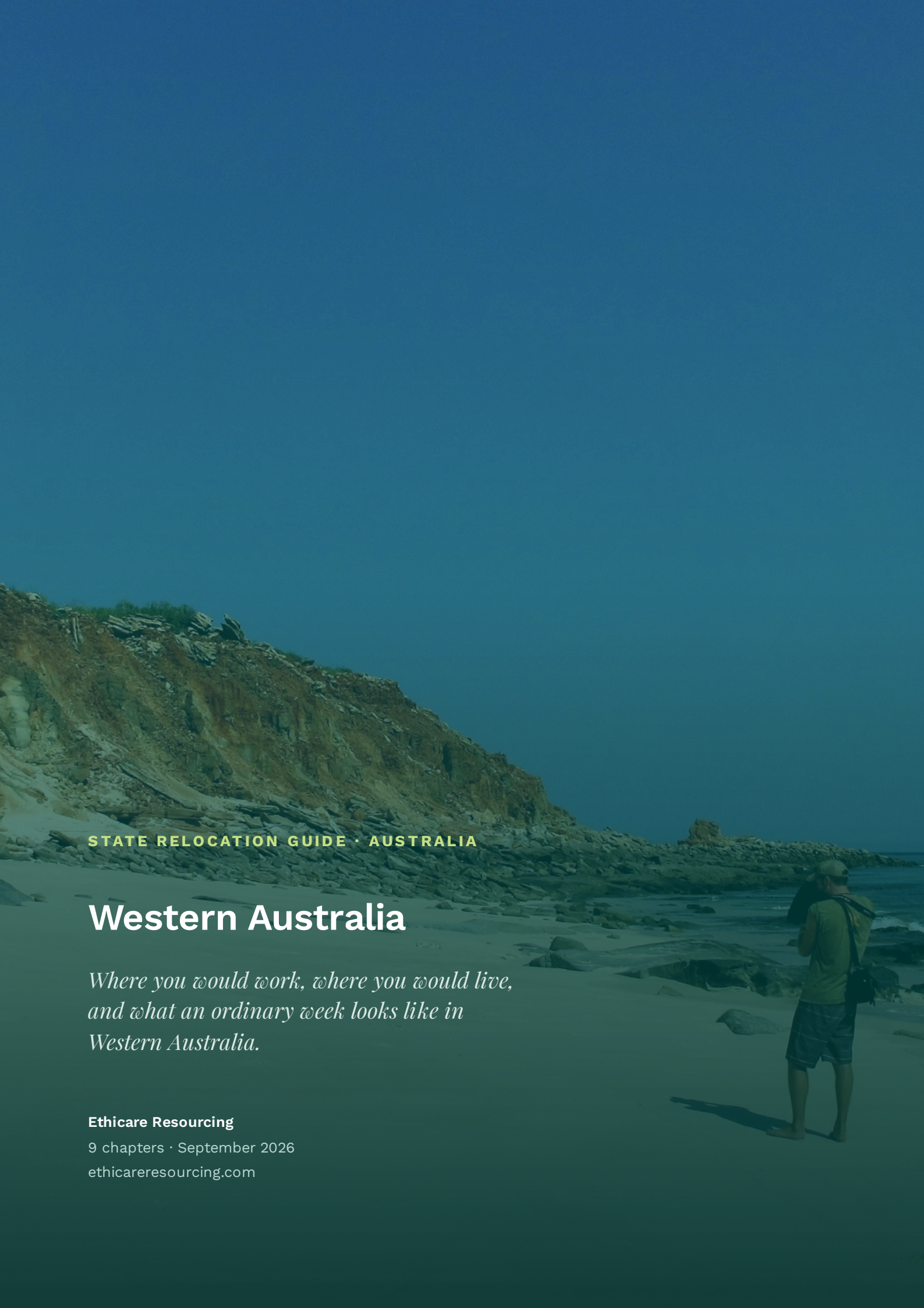


A person wearing a green shirt, dark shorts, and a cap stands on a sandy beach, looking out at the ocean. The beach is rocky with many large, flat stones. In the background, a steep, rocky cliff rises from the shore. The sky is a clear, deep blue.

STATE RELOCATION GUIDE • AUSTRALIA

Western Australia

*Where you would work, where you would live,
and what an ordinary week looks like in
Western Australia.*

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters • September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Western Australia

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Western Australia is a third of the continent with one city holding most of its people: Perth, the most isolated capital on earth, and one of the most pleasant places on it. For clinicians the west offers the country's best city beaches, an easier housing market than the east, and — beyond the city — the strongest incentives in Australian healthcare.

One city, one third of a continent

Perth sits on the Swan River between an endless white-sand coast and its own Mediterranean climate — two million people, a rebuilt riverfront, Kings Park looking over it all, and Fremantle's port-town streets at the river's mouth. It runs on its own clock, two or three hours behind the east coast, and closer to Jakarta than to Sydney — a fact that shapes everything from flight times to the evening news.

Beyond the city, the south-west corner is the liveable west: Bunbury's regional hub ninety minutes down the freeway, Busselton and the Margaret River wine coast beyond it, and tall-timber country to the southern capes. Then the state opens into its other identity — the Wheatbelt, the Goldfields around Kalgoorlie, and the vast north: the Pilbara's iron country and the Kimberley's gorges, where medicine is flown, salaries carry serious loadings, and the nearest tertiary hospital is a four-hour flight south.

The honest costs are distance and daylight: every east-coast conference, wedding and family visit is a five-hour flight, and the time gap makes cross-country calls a planning exercise. What the west gives back is the country's easiest big-city life — and the sunsets, because this is the only capital where the sun sets over the sea.



Spring in the south west. The wildflower season runs August to October, and it is a genuine event here

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

WA is the state people choose deliberately rather than drift into — and the one where the "will the distance bother you?" conversation matters most. Where we think it's the wrong answer, we say so.

The state, in nine numbers

~2.9M

People in a state covering a third of Australia — the emptiest map in this collection.

~2.2M

In Greater Perth — three-quarters of the state lives in the capital's coastal strip.

90+

Public hospitals and health campuses, from metropolitan tertiary centres to nursing posts a day's drive apart.

~12,500 km

Of coastline — more than the rest of the mainland states combined, most of it empty.

3,200 hrs

Of sunshine a year in Perth — the sunniest capital in Australia.

~100,000

In Greater Bunbury, the south-west's regional hub, ninety minutes from Perth.

UTC+8

Perth's clock — two to three hours behind the east coast, and aligned with Asia's business day.

5 hrs

Flying to Sydney or Melbourne. The isolation is real, and so is direct London — the only nonstop to Europe in the country.

2–4×

The scale of remote-area incentives in the north against a city package — the strongest loadings in Australian healthcare. Verified case by case.

Six things you only learn once you're here

The isolation cuts both ways

Five hours to Sydney means weddings, conferences and grandparents are a commitment. It also means Perth built everything it needs — and Bali is closer than Brisbane, which reshapes the holiday map entirely.

The beaches really are better

White sand, clear Indian Ocean water, and forty minutes of coast inside the metro area. The 6am swim-then-work routine is a mass habit, and the evening sea breeze — the Fremantle Doctor — is a daily institution with a name.

The time zone is a stealth feature

Aligned with Asia, awkward with the east coast: national meetings happen at 7am or not at all, and calls to Europe land in your evening – better than the east manages.

The mining economy sets the rhythm

Fly-in-fly-out rosters shape families, suburbs and Monday-morning flights north. It also underwrites the state's wages and the demand for health services in places you've never heard of.

"Regional WA" means something different

In the east, regional means two hours from the capital. Here it can mean Karratha or Broome – a flight, a loading, and a different life. The south-west is the gentle version; the north is the serious one.

Perth is easier than it looks from afar

The housing runs below Sydney and Melbourne, the commutes are shorter, the trains are new, and the lifestyle-per-effort ratio is the best of any Australian capital. People arrive sceptical and stay decades.

A note on Country

Perth stands on Whadjuk Noongar country, and the south-west is Noongar land from the coast to the wheat line. The north is different Country entirely – Yamatji, Pilbara nations and the Kimberley's many peoples, where Aboriginal health is central to the clinical work and community-controlled organisations lead much of it.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings, and in the north cultural safety is core clinical preparation, not a slide deck. Take the induction seriously.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Western Australia specifically. Anything true of Australia generally – Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools – lives once in [Moving to Australia](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Western Australia](#) for the full case including the distance question, and [Healthcare in WA](#), because the north is a different career from the city and deserves a clear-eyed look.

Why Western Australia

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Western Australia's case rests on one question answered honestly: how much does distance from the east coast matter to you? If the answer is "not much", Perth offers the best lifestyle-per-effort of any Australian capital — and the north offers packages the east can't match.

The arithmetic

Public-sector clinical pay is set by state awards, and we don't quote figures until we've verified them against the current instruments. The structure: Perth pay is broadly comparable with the eastern capitals while Perth housing runs clearly below Sydney and below Melbourne — closer to Brisbane's market, with less competition at inspections and shorter commutes to go with it.

Then there is the west's real differentiator: **remote loadings**. The Pilbara and Kimberley carry the strongest incentive packages in Australian healthcare — district allowances, housing subsidies or provided housing, additional leave, airfare assistance — because the state must compete with mining wages for every professional it sends north. For a defined chapter of two or three years, the north can reset a family's finances. We verify every package against the current award before quoting it, and the variation between postings is real.

What you trade: the five-hour flight to everything eastern, a time zone that makes national meetings awkward, and — in the north — heat, wet seasons and genuine remoteness.

A typical week

Monday to Friday

Perth: 20–40 minutes, with new train lines doing the heavy lifting. Bunbury: fifteen. The north: five, plus the airstrip.

Before work

The ocean swim — Cottesloe, Scarborough, Mettams Pool — then the commute. Perth's beach-before-work culture is the country's most committed.

After work

The Fremantle Doctor arrives mid-afternoon, the temperature drops, and the coast fills: sunset over the sea, the only capital that gets it.

Saturday

Kings Park, the river, sport – and Fremantle's markets and port-town streets for the afternoon.

Sunday

Rottneest by ferry for quokkas and snorkelling, the Swan Valley's cellar doors, or the national parks north and south of the city.

A long weekend

Margaret River – wine, surf and tall forests three hours south – or Bali, which is the shorter flight.

The six things people ask us

Is there enough work?

Will the isolation get to me?

Can I actually buy a house?

What is the north really like?

Is it good with children?

How international is it?

When we'd point you east

Your people are on the east coast

Five hours each way turns every visit into an event. The eternal rule: proximity to your people wins.

You need the deepest subspecialty pool

Perth's tertiary system is complete but smaller; the quaternary edge lives in Sydney and Melbourne.

You want big-city culture at scale

Perth's scene is good and growing; the east's is bigger. If headline acts weekly matter, look east.

The time zone would grind

If your work or family life runs on eastern-states hours, the two-to-three-hour offset is daily friction.

You want four seasons

Perth does hot dry summers and mild green winters – beautiful, but if autumn colour and frost matter, look to Victoria or Tasmania.

Where we'd steer you instead

Want the sunshine with east-coast proximity? [Queensland](#).

Want the biggest markets? [New South Wales](#) or [Victoria](#).

Weighing the Tasman? The master's [Australia vs New Zealand](#) chapter is the place to start.

In our experience

WA suits clinicians who want Australia's most liveable everyday – beaches, commutes, weather – and are honest with themselves about the distance from everywhere else. The ones who thrive stop flying east for weekends and start exploring their own coast.

Western Australia at a glance

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 3 of 9



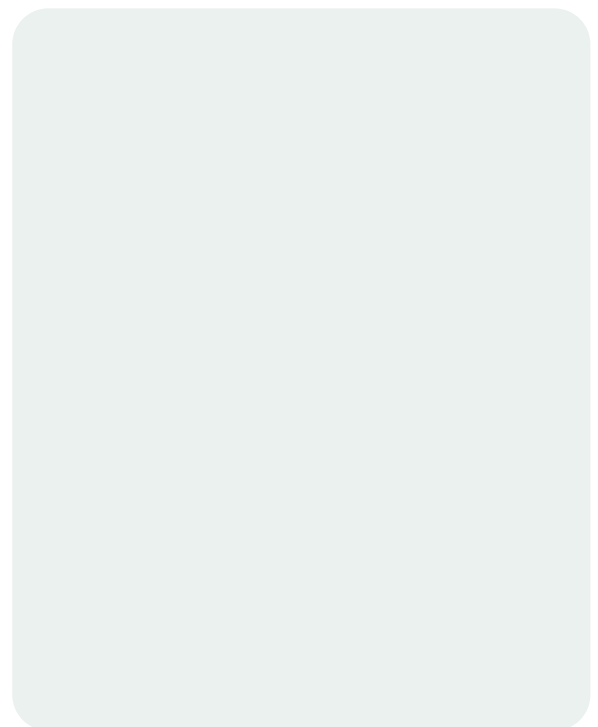
Western Australia is three climates stacked on one coastline: a Mediterranean capital, a green and gentle south-west, and a tropical north that runs on wet and dry seasons. Knowing which west you're moving to matters more here than in any state except Queensland.

The three wests

Perth and its coast is the Mediterranean west: hot dry summers cooled every afternoon by the Fremantle Doctor, mild green winters when the rain comes, and a metro area that runs seventy kilometres down a white-sand shore from Yanchep to Mandurah, with the Swan River and Kings Park at its heart.

The south-west corner is the green west: Bunbury's harbour hub, Busselton's long jetty, the Margaret River capes with their surf and vineyards, and karri forests to Albany's southern granite coast. Cooler, wetter, and the state's holiday heart — the one part of WA where "regional" means gentler, not harsher.

The north is the tropical west: the Pilbara's red iron country and company towns, then the Kimberley — gorges, boab trees, tides that swallow islands, and a wet season that closes roads from December to March. Broome faces the Indian Ocean sunset; inland, distances are measured in flight hours.



Where Perth sits, with the straight-line distance to Bunbury and Broome

The Kimberley – the north’s scale, in one tide

The seasons, in Perth

Summer

Dec – Feb

30–33°C

Hot, dry, sea-breeze cooled

Autumn

Mar – May

24–29°C

Long, warm, settled

Winter

Jun – Aug

18–20°C

Mild, green, showery

Spring

Sep – Nov

22–27°C

Wildflowers, everywhere

Indicative Perth daytime highs. The south-west runs a few degrees cooler and wetter; Broome and the north swap all of this for a wet (Nov–Apr) and a dry (May–Oct).

What the numbers don’t tell you

The Fremantle Doctor is real infrastructure. The afternoon sea breeze arrives most summer days with clockwork reliability, dropping the coast ten degrees. Locals schedule around it, cyclists curse it, and it is why Perth’s dry 33° beats the east’s humid 28°.

Winter is the green season. The rain comes June to August, the state turns green, and spring answers with the world's largest wildflower bloom – a genuine spectacle from the city's parks to the outback. Perth winter is mild enough that the beach walk never stops.

The north's wet season is a contract, not a mood. Cyclone watches, road closures, air-only access to some communities, and a build-up humidity that tests everyone. The dry season repays it with perfect blue months. If you're heading north, the induction is clinical preparation.

The sun is serious here too. Perth's UV matches Queensland's. Hats, rash shirts and 50+ are school policy and should be yours – the master's [Living in Australia](#) covers the everyday rules.

Where things are, in travel time

Perth → Fremantle

30 minutes by train down the river.

Perth → Bunbury

~1 hr 45 by road or the regional train.

Perth → Margaret River

~3 hr south to the wine capes.

Perth → Kalgoorlie

~6.5 hr by road, 1-hr flight – the Goldfields hub.

Perth → Karratha / Broome

2 / 2.5-hr flights. Driving is 16–22 hours and an expedition.

Perth → Sydney / Bali / London

5 hr / 3.5 hr / 17 hr nonstop – the flight map that explains the west.

Words you'll hear

The Doctor The Fremantle Doctor – the afternoon sea breeze with a schedule.

Freo Fremantle – the port town at the river mouth.

Rotto Rottnest Island – quokkas, snorkelling, the ferry day out.

FIFO Fly-in-fly-out – the mining roster that shapes half the state's rhythms.

Down south The south-west corner – Bunbury to the capes. The weekend direction.

Up north The Pilbara and Kimberley. The other direction, and the other life.

The wheatbelt The farm country inland of Perth – wildflowers in spring, salt lakes beyond.

SmartRider Perth's transport card – trains, buses, ferries.

The short version

Three wests: the Mediterranean capital, the green south-west, the tropical north. Perth's climate is the country's most pleasant; the north's is a contract with a payoff. Which west you choose decides everything – [Where clinicians live](#) is next.

Healthcare in Western Australia

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Western Australia organises its health system the way its geography demands: metropolitan services running Perth's tertiary network, and a single country service spanning a third of the continent. For a clinician, the choice of which is the choice of career.

The shape of the system

Perth's public care runs through **metropolitan health service groups** — north, south, east and children's — covering the capital's tertiary and general hospitals. Everything beyond the metro boundary belongs to the **country health service**: the largest single health geography in the world, running regional hospitals in Bunbury, Albany, Geraldton, Kalgoorlie, Karratha, Port Hedland and Broome, and district and nursing-post care across everything between.

Registration is national through Ahpra; hiring is service by service. The practical grammar: Perth roles compete like any capital's; south-west roles blend regional pace with reachable city; and the north recruits constantly, with packages built to compete against mining wages — the strongest loadings in Australian healthcare, described structurally here and verified case by case before we quote anything.

Aeromedical retrieval is the connective tissue — the flying-doctor tradition began in country like this — and telehealth carries more of the everyday than anywhere in the country. How Medicare and the public-private split work is national, and lives once in the master's [How the health system works](#).

What the work is like

Perth: a complete tertiary system

Full subspecialty coverage, major teaching hospitals and a children's service — a step smaller than Sydney's or Melbourne's at the quaternary edge, with correspondingly saner competition. The south-west: regional with a safety net

Bunbury anchors the state's gentlest regional medicine — real scope, a growing hub, and Perth ninety minutes away when complexity needs it.

The north: the serious posting

Karratha, Hedland, Broome and the Kimberley districts – broad scope, thin backup, heavy Aboriginal health caseload, and the packages to match. A defined chapter that changes careers and finances alike.

Aboriginal health is central, not adjacent

In the Kimberley and Pilbara it is much of the work, led in partnership with community-controlled organisations. Cultural preparation is clinical preparation.

FIFO shapes the caseload

Mining rosters drive occupational health, mental health and emergency patterns across the state – a distinctively western clinical rhythm.

Pay is set by state awards

Each profession has its instruments, with district allowances and packaging layered by remoteness. We quote figures only after verifying them against the current award; see [Pay & conditions](#).

FOUR WESTERN AUSTRALIAS

Everything past the metropolitan boundary belongs to a single country service – the largest health geography in the world. Within it, these are four genuinely different careers, and the loadings rise as you read down.

Perth and the metro

A complete tertiary system across metropolitan service groups: full subspecialty coverage, major teaching hospitals and a children's service. A step smaller than Sydney or Melbourne at the quaternary edge, with correspondingly saner competition.

The south-west

The state's gentlest regional medicine. Real scope and a growing hub, with Perth about ninety minutes away when complexity needs it – the usual first step for clinicians testing whether regional life suits them.

The Goldfields and mid-west

Regional hospitals a long way inland and up the coast, recruiting steadily. Wide scope, small teams, and a genuine step up in responsibility from a metropolitan equivalent.

The north

The Pilbara and the Kimberley: broad scope, thin backup, a heavy Aboriginal health caseload led in partnership with community-controlled organisations, and packages built to compete with mining wages. A defined chapter that changes careers and finances alike.

District allowances and remote loadings vary by town and by profession – we describe them structurally here and verify every figure against the current award before we quote it. See [Pay & conditions](#).

Working with Aboriginal communities

Perth stands on Noongar country, and the state's north is home to some of the oldest continuous cultures on earth. Community-controlled health organisations lead substantial care delivery in the Kimberley, the Pilbara and the Goldfields, and the state system works in formal partnership with them.

You are not expected to arrive expert. In the north especially, the cultural induction is core preparation: learn whose Country your service stands on, and treat the partnership as clinical business.

What to ask at interview

Which service and which site — and for country roles, exactly which town, because the north's postings differ enormously.

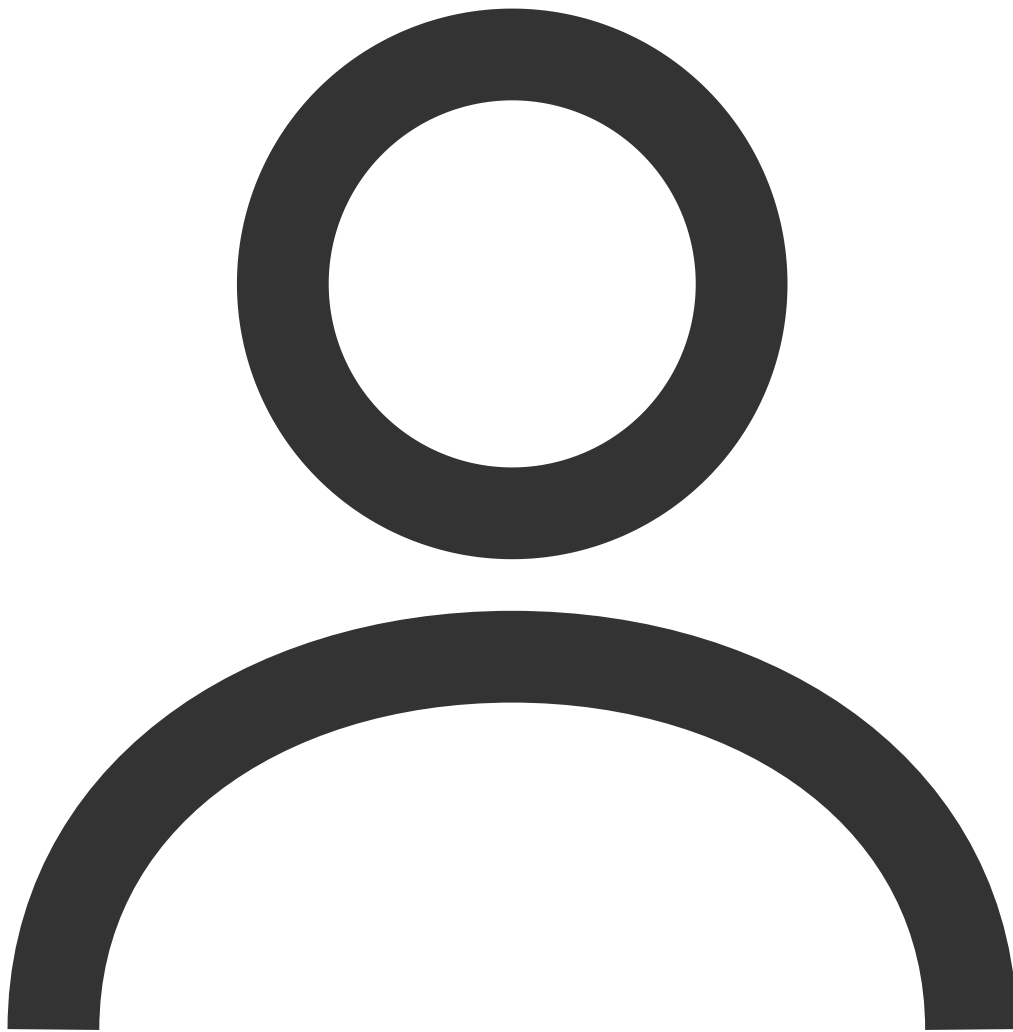
What is the roster pattern, and how are on-call, penalties and district allowances handled under the relevant award?

For the north: what precisely does the package include — housing provided or subsidised, leave loading, airfares, and for how long?

What is the wet-season operational plan, and what does it mean for my roster and my exits?

What supervision, orientation and cultural induction exists — and how does CPD work this far from the eastern cities?

Where does complex work refer to, and how much of the retrieval pathway do I own?



Sophie

Sophie's insight

The west is my honesty test: I ask about the east-coast family before anything else, because the flight is the only thing people regret. For the right family, Perth is the easiest good life in Australia – and a Broome or Hedland chapter, gone into with open eyes, resets finances in a way no eastern posting can.

Sophie Careem Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

Before you can start

Ahpra registration, English-language evidence and the visa that goes with your role are national processes, identical in every state. They are explained once, properly, in the master's [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

Ethicare



What we're recruiting for now, by profession and by state.
Master guide



How awards, allowances and remote loadings work – and what to verify before you sign.

Where clinicians live

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



Perth's geography hands you the choice plainly: the coast, the river, or the hills – with Fremantle as its own answer. Beyond the metro, the south-west corridor is the gentle regional option and the north is a different decision entirely.

COAST, RIVER OR HILLS

Perth's three home geographies, each with its own line of stops – and Fremantle standing slightly apart as its own answer.

Up the coast

The sunset side: premium sand first, family esplanades next, the growth corridor's newer estates beyond.

Cottesloe

Scarborough–Hillarys

Joondalup & north

Along the river to the port

Kings Park terraces and hospital-adjacent inner suburbs, running down the line to heritage-street Fremantle.

Subiaco & South Perth

Victoria Park

Fremantle · 30 min

Up into the hills

Tall-timber shade, cool nights and land – the tree change that keeps a forty-minute run to the wards.

Kalamunda

Mundaring

South of the metro, Rockingham's shore and the run toward Bunbury carry the same trade further: more house, more minutes on the train.

The coast

Cottesloe & the western beaches

The postcard – Norfolk pines, the ocean pool light, sunset over the sea. Perth's premium strip, priced like it, and still below eastern equivalents.

Scarborough to Hillarys

The family beach belt – renewed esplanades, surf clubs, newer apartments and the northern train line behind. Where the 6am-swim life is most affordable.

The northern corridor

Joondalup and beyond — the growth spine with its own hospital hub, new estates and beaches all the way up. The most house for the money on the coast.

Rockingham & the south coast

The southern mirror — penguin-island shores, naval-town roots, and value that surprises. The train makes it a real commute.

The river and the city

Fremantle

The port town that stayed itself — heritage streets, markets, working docks and a fierce local identity. Perth's most characterful address, thirty minutes down the line.

The riverside inner suburbs

Subiaco, Mount Lawley, South Perth — terraces and art-deco flats near Kings Park and the hospitals, with the river as the morning run.

The eastern corridor

Victoria Park through to the foothills — the value ring near the big hospital campuses, multicultural food strips included.

The hills

Kalamunda and Mundaring — jarrah forest, cooler nights, wineries and space, forty minutes from the wards. Perth's answer to a tree change without leaving town.

The south-west corridor

The kind of house the corridor is built on — and what the same budget looks like outside Perth.

Mandurah

Canals, estuary dolphins and the end of the metro line – technically regional, practically commutable, priced accordingly.

Bunbury

The regional hub – a working port city with its own hospital, beaches on three sides and house prices that reset expectations. The state's gentlest regional posting.

Busselton & the capes

The jetty town and the Margaret River coast beyond – wine, surf and forests, with growing health services and lifestyle demand pricing the best of it.

Albany

The southern granite coast – cooler, wilder, historically the state's first settlement, with a solid regional hospital and the south coast to itself.

The north, briefly and honestly

Karratha & Port Hedland

The Pilbara's iron towns – company-town economics, serious heat, and packages built to compete with mining wages. Two-to-three-year chapters, entered deliberately.

Broome & the Kimberley

Cable Beach camels and wet-season contracts – the most beautiful hard posting in the country, with Aboriginal health at the centre of the work.

Three things to check before you sign

The train line, then the beach. Perth's lines run the coast and the corridors – a suburb on the right one makes the hospital commute painless; the wrong one means the freeway.

Afternoon sun and the Doctor. West-facing rooms cook until the sea breeze lands; ask about orientation, shading and air conditioning like a local.

School catchments – and the visa fee question. Catchments bind here as everywhere; on a temporary visa, read the master's **School fees on a visa** before you budget.

Most clinicians we move rent for six to twelve months first – long enough to learn whether they're coast, river, Freo or hills people. Perth is generous with all four; the north is a separate conversation we have properly, package in hand.

Getting around

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

Perth transport is a good-news story the east rarely hears: a modern, expanding rail network, freeways that mostly flow, no toll roads at all — and beyond the metro, a state that runs on regional flights and long, straight, empty highways.

Perth: the rail spine

Perth's trains run the coast and the corridors — north to the beaches and Joondalup, south to Mandurah, east through the hills line, with new extensions still opening under the state's rail programme. The system is clean, fast and cheap by eastern standards, and everything runs on a **SmartRider** card with daily caps.

Buses fill the grid — including free city-centre routes — and the ferries cross the river as commute and pleasure alike. The practical rule matches the suburbs chapter: **choose your line before your suburb**, and test it at shift hours.

Driving, honestly

No tolls. None.

WA is the only mainland state without a toll road — the freeway bill is zero, forever, and easterners take a month to believe it.

The freeway has a rhythm

The Kwinana and Mitchell freeways bunch at peak like anywhere — but "peak" here is forty minutes, not ninety, and it clears.

Parking is manageable

Hospital and suburban parking is kinder than any eastern capital's. City parking costs; everywhere else mostly doesn't.

Country driving is its own skill

Road trains, roos at dusk, and fuel stops you plan rather than assume. North of the wheatbelt, distance is the hazard — rest, fuel, water, always.

The south-west run

Perth → Bunbury

Forrest Highway makes it ~1 hr 45; the regional train shadows it. The corridor commute is genuinely workable.

Beyond Bunbury

Busselton, the capes and Albany are road trips — easy, beautiful, and busiest on long weekends when half of Perth heads down south.

Regional coaches & trains

The state's regional network links the south-west and the Goldfields — useful, not roster-compatible. Country life assumes a car.

The wildflower detours

August to October, the wheatbelt roads become the attraction. Locals plan spring drives around the bloom maps.

Flying: the state's real transport system

Perth Airport

Direct London and Rome — the country's only nonstop Europe links — plus Asia in three to five hours, and the east coast in four to five.

The intrastate network

Karratha, Hedland, Broome, Kalgoorlie and Geraldton fly to Perth multiple times daily — the north's clinicians treat the flight south as the bus.

FIFO air traffic

Mining charters make Perth's regional terminals among the busiest in the country at 5am.

Book popular routes early in roster season.

The holiday map inverts

Bali in 3.5 hours beats Sydney in 5 — South-East Asia is the west's weekend-away shelf, and it reshapes how families holiday.

Distances worth knowing

Journey	Typical time
Perth CBD → QEII / Murdoch hospital precincts	10–20 min by train or road
Perth → Fremantle	30 min by train
Perth → Joondalup / Mandurah	~30 / ~50 min by train
Perth → Bunbury	~1 hr 45 by road or rail
Perth → Margaret River	~3 hr by road
Perth → Albany	~4.5 hr by road
Perth → Kalgoorlie	~6.5 hr by road, or a 1-hr flight
Perth → Karratha / Broome	2 / 2.5-hr flights
Perth → Sydney / Bali / London	5 hr / 3.5 hr / 17 hr nonstop

Off-peak estimates. North of the wheatbelt, check road conditions in the wet season and carry water always.

Licence conversion, buying and registering a car, and the practicalities of Australian driving are national topics, covered once in the master's [Living in Australia](#).

Cost of living

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



Perth runs the friendliest big-capital arithmetic in Australia: housing below Sydney and Melbourne, no tolls, shorter commutes, and salaries that stretch accordingly. The west's real cost lives on the flight line east — and this chapter prices both sides honestly.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare it against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The shape of the money

Clinical pay is set by state awards and is broadly comparable with the eastern capitals; we don't print figures until we've verified them against the current instruments. On the outgoings side Perth's advantage compounds quietly: the rent line runs below the big eastern capitals, the transport line has no tolls in it at all, and the mining state's one everyday gift is among the cheaper household energy on the grid.

The line that pushes back is **travel**. Every east-coast wedding, conference and grandparent visit is a five-hour flight; every European trip is long even with the nonstop. Families who fly often should budget it as a standing annual item, not an exception — it is the west's genuine cost of living, and pretending otherwise is how the isolation surprises people.

Up north, the arithmetic inverts into something unique: remote packages — loadings, provided or subsidised housing, extra leave, airfare assistance — against mining-town prices for everything else. Gone into deliberately, a northern chapter is the fastest financial reset in Australian healthcare. Every package is verified case by case before we quote it.

Renting, by area

Cottesloe & the western suburbs

The premium strip – Perth's top of range, still visibly below the eastern equivalents for the same postcode-to-sand maths.

The beach belt & river suburbs

Scarborough to Hillarys, Subiaco to South Perth – the comfortable middle, where most relocating clinicians land.

Fremantle

Character carries a modest premium; the port town remains gettable in a way its eastern equivalents are not.

The corridors & the hills

Joondalup north, Rockingham south, Kalamunda east – the value ring, on train lines, with the most house for the money.

Bunbury & the south-west

Regional prices with coast attached – the corridor's hub resets expectations; the capes price their postcard.

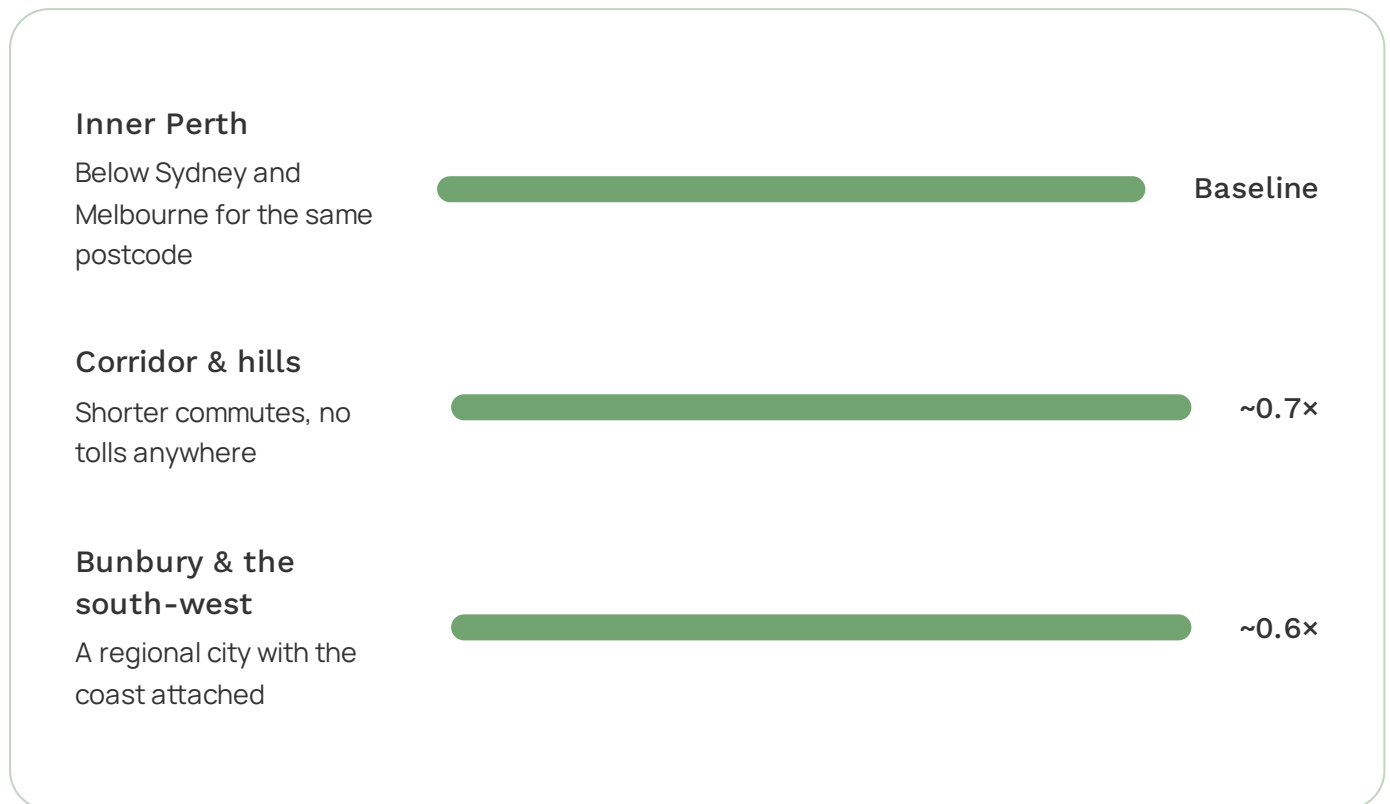
The north

Karratha, Hedland and Broome rents run mining-town high – which is exactly why packages include housing. Never take a northern role without the housing line settled.

THE FRIENDLIEST BIG-CAPITAL ARITHMETIC

Monthly rent for the same room or small one-bedroom, at true relative scale.

Perth's tiers sit closer together than the eastern capitals' – the west's real cost is not on this chart.



The rent line runs below the big eastern capitals, the transport line has no tolls in it at all, and power is among the cheaper on the grid. The west's real cost is the flight line east – five hours to the east coast, and worth budgeting as a standing annual item.

Indicative prices that change over time. The flights line is deliberate – the west's honest budget names it; most don't until December does.

The costs particular to the west

The flight fund

East-coast family means two to four crossings a year at five hours each way. Name it in the budget and the isolation stays theoretical.

Northern groceries

Remote-town freight prices everything up sharply – part of why the loadings exist. Budget the north on its own terms.

School fees on a temporary visa

WA charges circa \$4,000 per *family* rather than per child for certain skilled subclasses – indicative, with hardship waivers. The rule and the other states sit in the master's [School fees on a visa](#).

Health cover for your visa

Many visas require private cover, separate from Medicare – national detail, covered in Immigration & visas.

Work out your own numbers

Compare cities

Numbeo · cost of living



Perth and Bunbury prices against your current city.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Perth>)

Plan your budget



The Australian government's free budgeting tool.

(<https://moneysmart.gov.au/budgeting/budget-planner>)

Property



The west's own property portal – live rents and sales, suburb by suburb.

(<https://reiwa.com.au/>)

Master guide

The cost of relocating



Flights, shipping, bonds and the first ninety days – budgeted once, properly.
Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official data



Slower than the comparison sites, and the one to trust on the direction of travel.

(<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>)

The honest summary

Perth hands you the easiest big-capital budget in Australia — below-eastern rent, no tolls, cheaper power. The west's true cost is the flight line east: name it as a standing budget item and the isolation stays a fact, not a regret. The north is its own arithmetic — packages verified case by case, housing line settled first.

Food, shopping & the everyday

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

Perth's everyday life is built on a simple luxury the east never gets: the day ends with the sun going down over the sea. Around that daily show sits a food scene that has grown up fast, markets with real produce behind them, and the most unhurried big-city rhythm in the country.

Eating out

The small-bar decade

Perth's licensing reforms turned the city's lanes into a small-bar and bistro scene that surprises visitors who knew the old, early-closing town. The CBD and Northbridge carry it; the suburbs followed.

Fremantle does the weekend

The markets, the fishing-boat harbour's fish and chips, craft breweries in heritage warehouses — the port town is the state's default good afternoon.

The Indian Ocean menu

Crayfish from Geraldton, snapper and whiting off the coast, and the state's obsession: fresh crays at Christmas. The fish-and-chips baseline is set high.

No tipping, honest menus

The price is the price and waitstaff earn a wage — same national rule, same pleasant surprise.

Markets and what the state grows and pours

The **Swan Valley** is the city's own wine country — twenty-five minutes from the CBD, all cellar doors, breweries and long lunches — and **Margaret River** three hours south is the serious one: cabernet and chardonnay with global reputations, among surf breaks and karri forest. Between them the south-west grows truffles, olives, citrus and the state's famous marron.

Perth's market culture runs from Fremantle's institution through suburban growers' markets, with the wheatbelt and south-west supplying genuinely local produce. Whatever your community eats, the eastern corridor's food strips and the northern suburbs' grocers cover more of it than Perth's isolation would suggest — the master's **Finding your feet & your people** maps where communities cluster.

The rhythm of the week

The morning belongs to the ocean

Swim squads at dawn, the coast path full by six, coffee after — Perth's beach-before-work culture is the most committed in the country, and joining it is the fastest way in.

Sunset is the appointment

The only capital where the sun sets over the sea — the coast fills every clear evening, and "sundowners" is a schedule, not a word.

Sport, both codes, and the Derby

AFL rules the west — two teams, one Derby, allegiances expected. Cricket at the new stadium, netball, surf clubs: the club is the social engine here as everywhere.

FIFO shapes the social week

Half the state's social calendar works around mining rosters — the Thursday-night flight north and the week-on week-off rhythm are part of how friendships schedule themselves.

Honest limitations

Headline tours and blockbuster exhibitions reach Perth last or not at all — the east's cultural depth is a flight away.

Late-night everything is thinner than the east; the city runs early because the ocean does.

Specialist imported groceries can need planning; every community keeps its list and its favourite importer.

Beaches, forests & the north

Western Australia Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

The west's weekends run on its own scale: an island of quokkas offshore, the world's largest wildflower bloom inland, wine capes and karri forests down south — and, once a year if you're wise, the Kimberley, which makes everywhere else look small.

THE BLOOM THAT ORGANISES SPRING

12,000

WILDFLOWER SPECIES, AUGUST TO OCTOBER

Every spring the state stages the largest wildflower bloom on earth, and it reaches the suburbs as surely as the interior — Kings Park puts on its September show without you leaving town. Locals plan one proper drive around it every year.

The rest of the chapter works outward in rings — the Rottnest ferry first, the far north last and annual.

From the city

Rottnest / Wadjemup

The ferry-and-bicycle island — quokkas, snorkelling bays and no cars. Perth's signature day out, and better midweek.

The beach ladder

Cottesloe's pines, Scarborough's esplanade, Mettams' lagoon, and forty more — the city's coast alone could fill a year of Saturdays.

Kings Park

Bigger than Central Park, wilder at its edges, and the city's rooftop – the September wildflower display alone earns the visit.

The Swan Valley

Cellar doors, breweries and chocolate at twenty-five minutes – the lazy Sunday, institutionalised.

The hills

Kalamunda's trails, Mundaring's forest and the Bibbulmun Track's northern trailhead – a thousand kilometres of walking starts here.

Penguin & Seal Islands

Rockingham's wildlife ferries south of the city – the family default that visitors never expect.

Down south

Margaret River & the capes

Wine among the surf breaks, caves under the ridge, and Cape to Cape walking between two lighthouses – the state's great long weekend.

Bunbury & Busselton

Dolphins in Koombana Bay, the mile-long jetty with its underwater observatory – the corridor's easy family stops.

The tall timber

Karri and tingle forests around Pemberton and the Valley of the Giants treetop walk – cathedral country, four hours south.

Albany & the south coast

Granite headlands, whale season, and The Gap's ocean drama – the wilder, cooler weekend.

Wave Rock & the wheatbelt

The granite wave inland, salt lakes and silo art – the odd, wonderful interior day trip.

The wildflower spring

August to October the state hosts the world's largest bloom – twelve thousand species from the city's parks to the outback tracks. Plan one drive around it.

Up north, once a year

Ningaloo

The other reef – whale sharks in season, coral off the beach, no boats required. A flight or the great coastal road trip.

Kalbarri & the Coral Coast

River gorges, sea cliffs and the pink lake – the accessible north, six hours up the coast.

The Kimberley

Broome's Cable Beach, the Gibb River Road's gorges, Horizontal Falls, the Bungle Bungles – Australia's last great wilderness, and the dry-season expedition that resets your sense of scale.

Karijini

The Pilbara's slot canyons and red gorges – the inland masterpiece most easterners never see.

Useful links

Tourism

Tourism Western Australia



The state's official visitor site – regions, road trips and what's on.

(<https://www.westernaustralia.com/>)

Outdoors



Parks, trails and campgrounds – Karijini and the capes book out in season.

(<https://exploreparks.dbca.wa.gov.au/>)

The island



Ferries, bikes and bays – the Perth day out.

(<https://www.rotnestisland.com/>)

Practical



Journey planning, SmartRider and the new rail lines.

(<https://www.transperth.wa.gov.au/>)

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Western Australia. Everything national — Medicare, visas, registration, tax, super, schools — lives once in **Moving to Australia**. When you'd like to talk it through, **we're here** — no pressure, no pipeline.